

FESTIVAL ▼

Peace to the World

THE GLOBAL PEACE PRAYER FESTIVAL IN THIMPHU IS BRINGING TOGETHER AN UNPARALLELED ASSEMBLY OF EMINENT LAMAS FROM ALL SCHOOLS OF BUDDHISM FOR THE HEALING OF HUMANITY

In a world riddled with strife, comes an immersive celebration of hope. From November 4 to 19, Bhutan's capital Thimphu will host the Global Peace Prayer Festival (GPPF), an event envisioned by His Majesty Jigme Khesar Namgyel Wangchuck, the King of Bhutan, himself. The multidimensional event is being organised by the Bhutan government and is co-funded by the Indian government.

The first seven days of the festival will see two profound ceremonies occur simultaneously: the Global Peace Prayer, comprising non-sectarian Vajrayana prayers, and the large-scale Jabzhi Dhoechog ritual, which combines peaceful offerings with wrathful protection to cleanse and purify negative karma. More than 80 spiritual leaders will grace the Global Peace Prayer. November 12-14 will see the Kalachakra Initiation & Empowerment, a three-day initiation offering 'profound insights into the sacred interplay between the individual and the cosmos'.

His Holiness the Je Khenpo, the Supreme Spiritual Leader of Bhutan and the head of the Central Monastic Body (Zhung Dratshang), will preside over the first day of the Global Peace Prayer (Nov. 4) and all three days (Nov. 12-14) of the Kalachakra initiation. "When the Je Khenpo personally leads a major religious ceremony, it signifies the utmost sanctity and national importance of the event," says Yangchen C. Rinzin, media lead, GPPF.

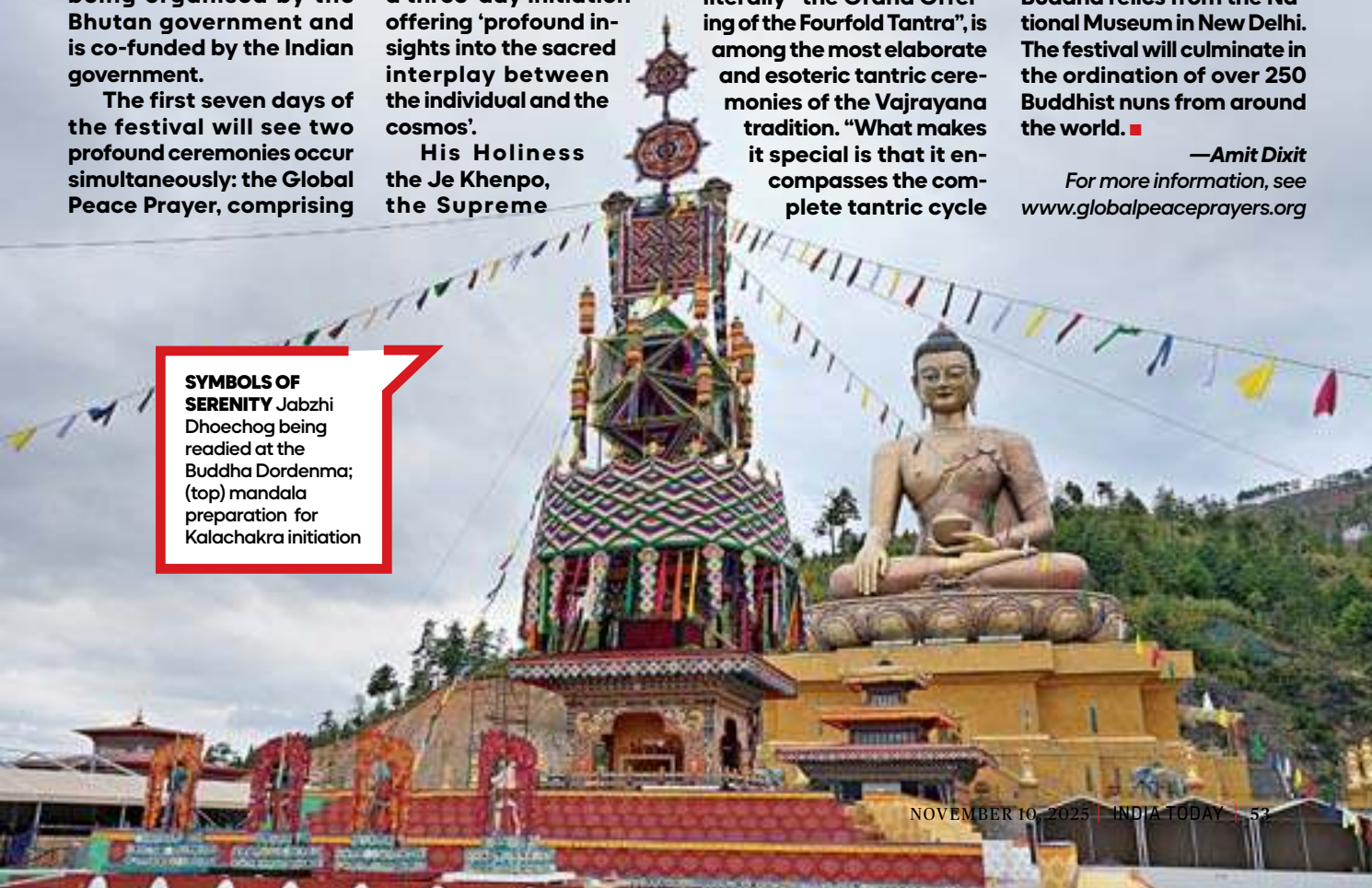
While the main events—the Global Peace Prayer and the Kalachakra initiation—will take place at the Changlimithang Ground, where a 12-foot-tall pavilion is being constructed to accommodate over 20,000 people, the Jabzhi Dhoechog will be held at Kuenselphodrang, the sacred site from where the Great Buddha Dordenma watches over Thimphu.

The Jabzhi Dhoechog, literally "the Grand Offering of the Fourfold Tantra", is among the most elaborate and esoteric tantric ceremonies of the Vajrayana tradition. "What makes it special is that it encompasses the complete tantric cycle of transformation, integrating multiple deities, mandalas and ritual systems into a single vast liturgical performance," explains Rinzin. It's rarely performed owing to its complexity, which requires ritual experts. "The full seven-day ceremony also demands a large number of monks and substantial resources. Moreover, it can only be conducted by those who have received direct empowerment and instruction within the strict transmission lineage," adds Rinzin.

Open to all, GPPF also features side events showcasing Bhutan's spiritual, artistic and community traditions, including sacred relic exhibitions, mask dances, live demonstrations of the 13 Traditional Arts, and even eco-treks, yoga sessions and pilgrimage walks to sacred sites. There will also be an exhibition of sacred Buddha relics from the National Museum in New Delhi. The festival will culminate in the ordination of over 250 Buddhist nuns from around the world. ■

—Amit Dixit

For more information, see www.globalpeaceprayers.org



SYMBOLS OF SERENITY Jabzhi Dhoechog being readied at the Buddha Dordenma; (top) mandala preparation for Kalachakra initiation